

C15 Building a Feedback Culture

Rebuilt from scratch. The original listed generic benefits of feedback. This version designs the specific feedback infrastructure a team needs.

Pillar	Communication	Difficulty	Level 2
Time Required	45-55 minutes	Group Size	4-12
Mode	Team facilitation	Format	In-person or remote
Prerequisites	V1 (Vulnerability Circle) strongly recommended. V3 (Structured Feedback Exchange) is complementary.	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Lack of proactive feedback culture, feedback only given during performance reviews, employees uncertain about their performance, positive feedback absent, constructive feedback avoided

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

Feedback is a dopamine delivery mechanism when done well and a cortisol bomb when done badly. The brain's reward system activates when feedback confirms progress ("you're on the right track") or provides a clear path to improvement ("here's specifically what would make this better"). This is because the dopamine system responds to progress signals, not just success signals.

Most teams lack feedback not because people don't want it but because there is no infrastructure for delivering it. Without agreed cadence, format, and norms, giving feedback requires a disproportionate amount of social courage each time. Building the infrastructure makes feedback a system rather than an act of individual bravery.

The Exercise

Phase 1: The Feedback Frequency Audit (8 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Quick question for everyone. In the last month, how many times did you receive feedback from a colleague or from me? Not in a formal review. In the normal flow of work. Write down the number."

Collect numbers anonymously. Most teams average 0-2 per month. The gap between what people want (regular, specific feedback) and what they get (almost none) is the problem this exercise solves.

Phase 2: Barrier Identification (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Why don't we give feedback more often? Be honest. What stops you? And what kind of feedback do you wish you received but don't?"

Common barriers: don't want to offend, not sure it's my place, don't know how to frame it, no natural moment to give it, fear that constructive feedback will damage the relationship, assume the person already knows.

Common wants: knowing specifically what they're doing well (not just "good job"), hearing about issues before they become performance problems, getting feedback close to the event rather than months later in a review.

Phase 3: Designing the Feedback System (15 minutes)

The team designs its own feedback infrastructure. This is not the manager imposing a system; it is the team building one they will actually use.

Four design questions:

11. Cadence: how often will we give and receive feedback? (Weekly? After each project milestone? In every 1:1?)
12. Format: how will feedback be delivered? (In person, written, structured using SBI from V3, informal?)
13. Balance: what ratio of positive to constructive? (Research suggests 3:1 as a minimum for the positive to register.)
14. Safety: what do we do when feedback lands badly? (The team needs a recovery protocol: 'That feedback didn't land well. Can we revisit it?')

Write the agreed system on a single page. Post it visibly. The manager commits to modelling it first.

Phase 4: Practice Round (10 minutes)

Each person gives one piece of positive feedback to someone else on the team, using the agreed format. Positive feedback first reduces the threat response and builds the habit before introducing constructive feedback.

WHAT TO SAY

"We're starting with positive feedback because it's actually harder to deliver well than most people think. 'Good job' is not feedback. 'The way you handled the client's pushback in yesterday's meeting by acknowledging their concern before presenting the alternative, that was exactly what the situation needed' is feedback. Be that specific."

Phase 5: Close (5 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"We now have a feedback system that we designed together. My commitment: I will give at least two pieces of specific feedback to team members this week, one positive and one constructive. My ask: each of you does the same. One piece of feedback to one colleague. Not a big deal. Just a start."

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
The team's feedback frequency numbers are not zero but the feedback they describe is vague ("good job" or "needs improvement")	"Those count as recognition and evaluation, but they're not quite feedback. Feedback is specific enough that the person knows exactly what to do more of or differently. Let's use that as our quality standard."
Someone says "I don't need feedback, I know what I'm doing"	"That confidence is great. Feedback isn't about not knowing. It's about blind spots. Every person, no matter how skilled, has things they do that land differently than they intend. Feedback makes those visible."
The team designs an overly complex feedback system	"If the system requires a form, a scheduled meeting, and a rubric, nobody will use it. What's the simplest version of this that we would actually do? Start there. We can add complexity later if we need it."

Signs This Is Working

Timeframe	What to Look For
During the session	- The frequency audit produces honest (usually low) numbers - Barriers are specific and real, not abstract - The feedback system feels simple enough to actually use
Within 2-4 weeks	- Feedback frequency increases measurably - At least one person gives unsolicited constructive feedback using the agreed format - The manager models the system consistently
CLOVER ERA data (4-6 weeks)	- Communication scores improve - Feedback culture signals strengthen - Vulnerability scores may also improve (giving feedback requires trust)
Red flags	If the system exists on paper but feedback frequency hasn't changed, the barriers identified in Phase 2 were not actually addressed. Revisit which barrier is really blocking the team.

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
V1: Vulnerability Circle	Trust is the prerequisite for honest feedback. V1 builds the trust; C15 builds the infrastructure.	Run V1 before C15
V3: Structured Feedback Exchange	V3 teaches the skill of giving and receiving feedback. C15 builds the system for making feedback ongoing. They are a pair.	Run C15 and V3 within the same month
C9: Conflict Communication	Undelivered feedback eventually becomes conflict. C15 prevents this by making regular feedback normal.	C15 is preventive; C9 is responsive